Erich Hanke – who afterward enjoyed a long career in the SED administration – blarneyed the episode in his 1970 autobiography:

Under the difficult living conditions, in which human weaknesses and human strength quickly become apparent, I was impressed by the personality of comrade Honecker. He is a man of excellent qualities. Modesty, a sense of justice, the ability to make any personal sacrifice for the good of the people, courage, willpower and energy are coupled with great intelligence, extensive knowledge, great experience, a clear view of the essentials, and perseverance. The demands of imprisonment and the many hours of discussions revealed a good person and an outstanding communist.

In later years, the story of Honecker the prisoner became an essential part of the communist construction of his persona, perhaps the most critical part.

As Hitler governed from beneath the ruins, the Nazi chain of command was breaking down. By April, when a tidal wave of near-starving refugees snaked into Berlin from East Prussia, chronic supply problems worsened. And as Germany's situation grew ever more perilous, the Red Army began assaulting Berlin from its bridgeheads on the Oder River on 16 April. Four days later – Hitler's birthday – Honecker witnessed the first Soviet salvos into the heart of the capital.

I shall never forget the midday hours of this last Führer's birthday. The first Soviet artillery shell landed right opposite the Barnimstraße women's prison, the second one immediately beside the prison where we were held. The next hits were